

THE ULTIMATE DEADLIFT GUIDE

**AVOID COMMON MISTAKES &
NAIL THE PERFECT SETUP
EVERY TIME**

BY DIGITAL BARBELL®

HOW TO:

THE ULTIMATE DEADLIFT GUIDE

BY DIGITAL BARBELL®



Digital Barbell ®

Digital Barbell makes getting in shape, and actually looking like you work out simple by giving you the plan, the coaching, and the accountability you need.

Digital Barbell
Wimberley, Texas
www.digitalbarbell.com





Jonathan & Blakley Fletcher | Owners of Digital Barbell

We're full-time online coaches helping regular people just like you get in the best shape of their lives without fad diets, hard-core workouts, or any of the unnecessary nonsense that's so common on social media.

We've racked up thousands of coaching hours both in person and online, and we're honored to be a part of our client's health and fitness journeys.

We've got a [Podcast](#), a [YouTube](#) channel, and we're active every day on [Instagram](#).

It's nice to meet you!

INTRODUCTION

Whether you're brand new to lifting weights or you've done deadlifts for years, you downloaded the right guide.

Deadlifts get a bad rap as being "bad for your back", when in fact they're the most useful exercise (when done properly) for building a strong, injury-resistant back.

If you can deadlift significantly more than your bodyweight, the physical demands of everyday life just seem easier.

In this guide, you'll learn the 5-Step Deadlift Setup we teach our online coaching clients.

We'll also help you avoid the most common mistakes people make when deadlifting.

1. WHAT YOU NEED

You probably already realize this, but you're going to need a barbell, and some weights. The brands you choose don't matter for deadlifts, but the diameter of your weights does.

Standard 45lb "Olympic" plates (or weights), and all rubber "Bumper" plates are 17.7" in diameter. This matters because it dictates the height the barbell sits off of the ground.

When those weights are loaded on a barbell, that puts the barbell at about 9" off of the ground, right where we want it for a well-done deadlift.

What we don't want is to load smaller diameter plates that put the barbell at a very low starting position and the lifter in a bad start position.

Many gyms these days have rubber bumper plates that vary in weight (from 10 to 45lbs) and thickness, but all have a standard 17.7" diameter.

"SHOES MATTER."

There are as many opinions on footwear as there are feet. Here's our advice on what shoes to wear for safe deadlifting.

Choose a snug, secure shoe with a solid and flat bottom. Since the deadlift involves lifting heavy weights, you want to be well connected to the floor without any movement of the shoe.



Jonathan in Reebok lifters

Some prefer to wear proper weight lifting shoes with a slightly wedged sole, while others prefer a flat pair of trainers, or “barefoot” style shoe. Either option is fine.

However... ***DO NOT DEADLIFT IN RUNNING SHOES OR OTHER CURVED/SOFT SOLE SHOES***

The last thing you want to do is get off balance during a heavy deadlift, and put unnecessary strain on your back.

If you have a question about a particular pair of shoes, shoot us an [email](#) and we'd be happy to help!

“SHOULD YOU USE A LIFTING BELT?”

WHAT WEIGHTLIFTING BELTS ARE DESIGNED TO DO

Weight lifting belts are designed to give you a stable *loop* around your torso to create pressure *against*. That pressure is what keeps your back stable during a heavy lift. They aren't intended to (and won't) hold your back in place during a heavy lift.

Belts aren't a substitute for proper form (which you'll have nailed by the time you finish with this guide!) either. They simply allow you to lift heavier weights, once your form is locked in.

BREATHING & BRACING

We teach a breathing technique called the **Valsalva Manueuver** that's helpful for all heavy lifting, including times when you use a belt. You actually perform the Valsalva in your everyday life without even knowing it. The Valsalva is a deep held breath, that is sealed tight against a closed throat, creating intra-abdominal pressure. This pressurized held breath creates a stable chamber of air that helps support the spine and abdomen during a lift or other movement.

Here's how you do it.

- Before the lift, take a deep breath into your belly. Note that this breath actually pushes your belly OUT vs sucks your belly IN.
- Place your tongue on the roof of your mouth and close off your throat.
- Press your held breath against your closed throat to create pressure in your stomach and lungs.
- Perform the lift with the held breath and braced/flexed abdominals.
- Once the load is moved, you can let the breath out.

The Valsalva is safe for almost everyone. If you have a history of getting lightheaded or have past heart or blood pressure problems, talk to your coach before lifting heavy with the Valsalva maneuver.



CLICK THE VIDEO ABOVE to see how to use a lifting belt

“SHOULD YOU USE LIFTING STRAPS?”

Lifting straps are fabric or leather strips that transfer some of the work from your grip to your wrists. This can be helpful when your grip starts limiting the amount of weight that you can deadlift. However, straps should be reserved for use once you already have developed a strong grip. If you don't have a strong grip, you'll never get one by using straps.

The straps we use can be found in our Amazon store [HERE](https://amzn.to/46KuQna):

<https://amzn.to/46KuQna>



CLICK THE VIDEO ABOVE to see how to use lifting straps

2. HOW TO DEADLIFT

HOW TO WARM UP FOR DEADLIFTS

Your warmup should be broken up into 2 sections that are **key** for injury prevention. The first is the general warmup. The general warmup should raise your body temperature, increase blood flow to your muscles and tendons, and put the muscles being worked through full ranges of motion.

GENERAL WARM UP

Here is a sample general warmup that we would give our training clients:

2:00 Jog or Bike

Then:

2 Rounds of:

5 Inchworm Pushups

10 Good Mornings

15 Air Squats

The second section of your warmup for deadlifts are the reps you do building up to your working weight for the day. In

other words... You don't just load up the maximum you're going to lift and get after it, you build up to it.

We like to increase the weight of the warmup sets as we decrease the reps per set. That's how to balance actually preparing your body mentally and physically, without wearing yourself out.

SPECIFIC WARM UP

Here's an example of how we'd recommend warming up for a workout that included 3 sets of 5 deadlifts at 275lbs:

1 Set of 10 RDL's with the empty bar

1 Set of 5 reps @ 135lbs

1 Set of 3 reps @ 185lbs

1 Set of 3 Reps @ 225lbs

1 Set of 1 Reps @ 255lbs

Here's an example of how to warm up for a set of deadlifts at 135lbs:

1 Set of 10 RDL's with the empty bar

1 Set of 5 Reps @ 65lbs

1 Set of 3 Reps @ 95lbs

1 Set of 1 Rep @ 115lbs

Again, as you increase the weight, decrease the reps.

Ok, before you actually start these warm up sets, we need to dial in your form.

THE 5-STEP DEADLIFT SETUP

We learned to deadlift *correctly* in 2013 while visiting Mark Rippetoe of Starting Strength fame. Since then we've taught thousands of people how to deadlift safely following 5 simple steps. Let's get right to it!

Step 1: Stand with your feet under the bar so that the bar is over the middle of your foot (or knot in your shoes laces). This will place the bar ~1 inch from the shin in most people. Put



5 Step Set Up | Step 1

your heels 8-12 inches apart, and point your toes out slightly. It should look like this:

Step 2: WITHOUT BENDING YOUR KNEES, take an overhand grip about 1.5” outside of your legs. **DO NOT ROLL THE BAR.**

!! Bending the knees and rolling the bar is where lifters commonly mess up this step.

It should look like this:



5 Step Set Up | Step 2

Step 3: Bend your **knees** until your shins touch the bar. **DO NOT LOWER YOUR HIPS, AND DO NOT ROLL THE BAR.**

Now push your knees out slightly into your elbows. It's ok if your back is rounded at this point.

!! Rolling the bar toward your legs is where lifters commonly mess up this step.

It should look like this:



5 Step Set Up | Step 3

Step 4: Squeeze your chest up and out so that your back becomes flat. You'll be tempted to lower your hips while you do this, so don't let that happen! Keep your neck in line with your spine and look at the floor about 12 feet in front of you.

!! Letting the hips drop lower than you set them in step 3 is where lifters commonly mess up this step.

It should look like this:



5 Step Set Up | Step 4

Step 5: Fill your stomach with air, flex your abs (against your belt if you're wearing one), and drag the bar up your shins and thighs **maintaining contact** until your hips and knees are fully open and you are standing up straight. The video below shows the path of the barbell.



[CLICK TO VIDEO](#) to see Blakley perform the set up and proper bar path

You did it! The perfect deadlift! But wait, you're not done! You need to get the bar back down to where it started.

HOW TO PUT THE BAR DOWN BETWEEN REPS

Putting the bar down happens the same way it went up, just faster. You still need to keep your back straight, and the bar needs to go directly down, not away, from your body.

Simultaneously unlock your hips and knees while pushing your hips **back**. The bar will start to go down as you bend over. Slide the bar down your legs maintaining contact until the weights touch the floor. If you did it right, the bar will be exactly where you started, right over the middle of your foot.



Blakley demonstrating the proper ending position

3. ALL ABOUT REPS

DEAD STOP VS TOUCH & GO DEADLIFTS

If you come from a CrossFit background like us, you've done plenty of "touch and go" deadlifts. You tap the ground between reps vs. taking a brief pause to reset.

If you're using the deadlift to train for strength, you may be better off doing "dead stop" deadlifts that eliminate the stretch reflex and bounce off of the floor.

If you're doing a set of dead stop deadlifts with multiple reps, you won't redo the entire 5 step setup between reps. You'll resume the set up at step 3 (bringing your shins to the bar) each rep.



[CLICK TO VIDEO](#) to see Jonathan demonstrating “dead stop” deadlifts



[CLICK THE VIDEO](#) to see Jonathan demonstrating “touch & go” deadlifts

4. LIFT VARIATIONS & SPECIALTY BARS

There are a variety of deadlift versions you have probably seen and/or executed yourself.

CONVENTIONAL DEADLIFTS

The conventional deadlift done with your arms outside your stance is our favorite deadlift variation for most of our training clients.

We train the conventional deadlift primarily because this version trains the posterior chain the most effectively while also translating to a motion you would likely encounter out in the world (#functionaltraining).



Jonathan performing a conventional deadlift



Blakley & Jonathan demonstrating a sumo deadlift

SUMO DEADLIFTS

Sumo Deadlifts are done with a wide stance and your hands between your legs. The Sumo stance shortens the range of motion of the deadlift because of the wide stance.

A sumo deadlift shifts more of the work to the glutes and the hips over the entire posterior chain. While we focus primarily on conventional deadlifts for our clients we will supplement with the sumo deadlift for additional deadlift volume.

TRAP BAR DEADLIFTS

The “trap” or “hex” bar is a specialty deadlift barbell that you stand inside of.

The main benefit of a trap bar is to ensure the weight is directly over mid foot. That being said, bracing and controlling any movement of the barbell is still very important in this type of deadlift.

At Digital Barbell, we don’t often prescribe this type of deadlift to our clients unless they request specifically to use a trap bar for deadlifting.



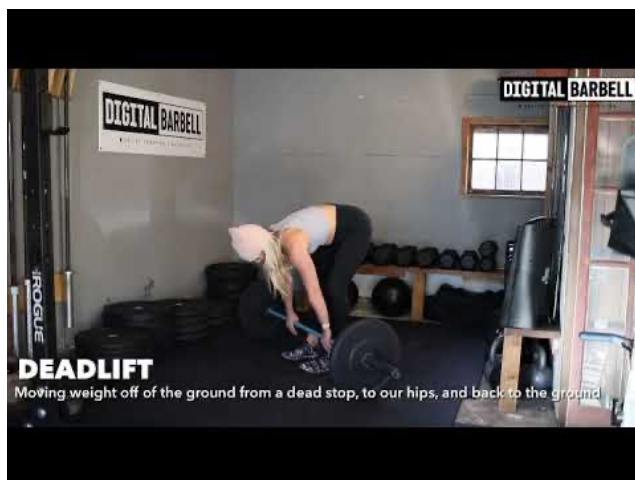
ROMANIAN DEADLIFTS

We ❤️ Romanian Deadlifts or “RDL’s”. The Romanian Deadlift starts from the standing position (top of the deadlift) and ends with the barbell slightly below your knees.

Since the weight never touches the floor, your entire body is at work to stabilize and stop the barbell at the end of each rep.

Unlike the full range of motion conventional deadlift, your knees don’t bend much at all during the RDL. That lack of knee flexion puts a giant stretch on your hamstrings which builds muscular strength and size.

We program RDL’s for our training clients on a weekly basis for accessory work.



[CLICK THE VIDEO](#) to see the difference between a deadlift and an RDL

5. COMMON DEADLIFT MISTAKES

The deadlift gets a bad reputation as being *dangerous*, which is totally bogus. The deadlift only becomes dangerous when done with bad form, or when you try to lift more than you should.

That being said, there are common mistakes we see lifters make when executing a deadlift. Let's go over the top 5 so they don't happen to you!

MISTAKE 1:

THE SQUATTY DEADLIFT

This is the most common fault we see!

If you squat down to grip the barbell instead of hinging at the waist with straight knees you'll end up in the squatty deadlift position.

The result of this set up is that your knees will be blocking the path of the bar causing your hips to shoot up as you start the lift. That will put unnecessary strain on you slow back, and disengage the muscles of the posterior chain.



Squatty Deadlift

- Hips too low
- Knees forward
- Shoulders directly over BB
- Quad dominant



Deadlift

- Hips above knees
- Shins vertical
- Shoulders just in front of BB
- Glute and hamstring dominant

Note the difference in the set up between a squatty deadlift and a proper deadlift set up

MISTAKE 2:

YANKING THE BAR OFF OF THE FLOOR

You're psyched to lift the weight, so you get set, and then jerk the bar off the floor. Wrong move!

The safest way to deadlift is to be tight, have tension throughout your body, and have no *slack* in your arms or anywhere else.

You should be like a tightly coiled spring, ready to go. Two helpful cues you can remember to avoid yanking the barbell off the floor are:

1 - Listen for the click - If your body is tight and loaded you'll put enough tension on the barbell to make the sleeves of the bar "click" against the weights. This should happen before you lift, not as you start to lift.

2 - Push the floor away - If your goal is to push the floor away with your feet, you're not trying to yank the weight off of the floor. Think about driving through your feet as you lift.

MISTAKE 3:

SPENDING TOO MUCH TIME IN THE SETUP

We want you to be 100% confident that you're ready to lift once you've done the 5 step set up.

Avoid getting set and then spending more than a few seconds in position before you go. Your hamstrings should be under a lot of tension and we don't want you accumulating extra fatigue that may compromise your strength or safety.

Get set, and let 'er rip!

MISTAKE 4:

LOSING YOUR FORM ON THE LAST REP

When you finish your last rep, you're ready to be done. But don't let that be a reason to release your form and put your back at risk. Stay braced until the weight is safely on the floor.

MISTAKE 5:

TRYING TO ADD WEIGHT TOO QUICKLY

For most people, the deadlift is their strongest lift. It can be tempting to try and add weight to the bar before your ready, just because you think you can.

Our experience tells us that the safest way to make progress is to only add 5-10 pounds to your working sets of deadlifts per week (only if your previous week's reps are executed at 100% form). This way you're less likely to get hurt & you're more likely to make continued progress over a longer period of time.

SAMPLE DEADLIFT PROGRAM

Before we wrap up, we want to give you an idea of how you can build strength safely with the deadlift.

Beginners should start with a “linear strength progression”. That simply means that you’ll add weight to your lifts in a linear fashion each week. As we said earlier, we prefer 5 to 10lb jumps each week on the deadlift.

SAMPLE DEADLIFT PROGRESSION

WEEK 1	WEEK 2	WEEK 3	WEEK 4
3x5 at 75% effort	3x5 at 5-10lbs more than last time	3x5 at 5-10lbs more than last time	3x5 at 5-10lbs more than last time

That may look too simple but it works! Continue to add 5-10lbs (slowing to 5-lbs as it starts to get heavy) until you stop making progress (then reach out if you need to know what to do next!). This is where a coach comes in hand #shamlessplug.



Blakley throwing down on some deadlifts in competition

At Digital Barbell we believe that your training should be fun, and that it should work. Our training methodology has evolved over the last 15 years to include the best of barbell strength training, body building, and conditioning. We believe you truly can have it all without killing yourself 7 days a week in the gym.

Below is a sample from one of our **STRENGTH PROGRAMS** to give you an idea of what a week would look like incorporating deadlifts and some of the accessories into a week.

SAMPLE STRENGTH PROGRAM

DAY 1:

GET WARM

On a 5:00 clock, moving for quality of:

30 Jumping Jacks

10 Air Squats

30 Mountain Climbers

10 Push Ups

GET FLEXY

10 Chest Openers

:60 Couch Stretch per side

BACK SQUAT

3 Sets of 5 Reps, across at the same weight

Add 5-lbs if all sets & reps were successful last time

BENCH PRESS

3 Sets of 5 Reps, across at the same weight

Add 5-lbs if all sets & reps were successful last time

DUMBBELL BENCH PRESS

3 HARD Sets, across

8 to 15 reps

If you got 15 reps for all 3 sets last week, move up.

CABLE (or BAND) PUSH DOWNS

3 HARD Sets

10 to 20 reps per set

PUSH UPS

2 MAX REP SETS

Rest about :60 between efforts

COACHES NOTE:

WARM UP REMINDER FOR BARBELL LIFTS

5 to 10 reps with the empty barbell

5 reps at 65% WW

3 reps at 75% WW

2 reps at 85% WW

1 rep at 95% WW

(WW = Working Weight)

DAY 2:

GET WARM

10 Boot Strappers

10 Good Mornings

then

2 Rounds of:

10 Cossack Squats

10 Shoulder Taps in Plank Position/arm

10 In & Outs

GET FLEXY

:30 Sampson stretch per leg

DEADLIFT

3 Sets of 5 Reps, across at the same weight

Add 5-lbs if all sets and reps were successful

DUMBBELL ROW

3 HARD Sets, across

8 to 15 reps

If you got 15 reps for all 3 sets last week, move up.

REVERSE FLY

3 HARD Sets, across

8 to 15 reps

If you got 15 reps for all 3 sets last week, move up.

LAT PULL DOWNS (wide grip)

3 HARD Sets

10 to 20 reps per set

BANDED FACE PULLS

2 Hard Sets

Looking for 15+ reps per set

DAY 3:

GET WARM

2 Rounds for Quality:

10 Lunges

:45 Plank

10 Air Squats

:45 Reverse Plank

GET FLEXY

10 Slow cossack squats

:90 Couch Stretch per side

BACK SQUAT

3 Sets of 5 Reps, across at the same weight

Add 5-lbs if all sets & reps were successful last time

STRICT PRESS

3 Sets of 5 Reps, across at the same weight

Add 5-lbs if all sets & reps were successful last time

DUMBBELL RDL

3 HARD Sets, across

8 to 12 reps

If you got 12 reps for all 3 sets last week, move up.

CALF RAISES

2 Sets

15 to 20 reps

HANGING LEG RAISES (Strict)

3 MAX REP SETS

Rest about :60 between efforts

Alt: Knee Raises

DAY 4:

GET WARM

1-2-3-4-5 reps of:
jumping air squats
inch worm push ups
v or tuck ups

Perform 1 of each, then 2 of each... at a nice steady pace.

GET FLEXY

10 Spider + Reach per side

CLOSE GRIP BARBELL BENCH PRESS

3 Sets of 5 Reps, across at the same weight
Add 5-lbs if all sets & reps were successful last time

BARBELL CURL

3 HARD Sets, across
8 to 12 reps
If you got 12 reps for all 3 sets last week, move up.

DUMBBELL LTE

3 HARD Sets, across
8 to 12 reps
If you got 12 reps for all 3 sets last week, move up.

HAMMER CURLS (non-alternating)

3 HARD Sets, across
8 to 15 reps
If you got 15 reps for all 3 sets last week, move up.

HOLLOW ROCKS

2 MAX REP Sets
Rest at least :60 between sets

We hope you found this guide helpful. If you have any questions at all, don't hesitate to [reach out](#).

Hey before you go, be sure and subscribe to our podcast on either [Apple](#) or [Spotify](#).

All our best,

Jonathan & Blakley Fletcher
Digital Barbell ®

